



NIC has also developed a solution called 'System for Automating Milk Procurement' (SAMP), using Java and SQLite to measure the quality and content of the milk when the farmer brings his produce



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developed using Java and SQLite. With the previous system, farmers would contribute their produce in the morning and a sample would be sent to the lab to test for quality details like fat content, protein and water content. Based on this test, the price for each farmer's produce was decided, and the farmer would be informed about the price only in the evening. "With the introduction of SAMP, the quality and content of the milk can be measured when the farmer brings his produce, and the price is set right away," Khalid reveals.

About a year ago, an SMS response system was also created by the team for auto-answering farmers' SMS queries using a Kannel SMS Gateway. Farmers can type in key words like 'Milk rate', 'Monthly payment', etc, to the number provided, and the database generates the reply in the form of an SMS. The committee is also developing a dairy portal, through which farmers can access information about periodical reports and statements, statistical reports, government orders and circulars in Malayalam. This is due to be launched early next year.

Not a smooth journey

Despite the advantages, migrating to open source was not an easy task. One of the main challenges was training the employees at each society. "The staff had to be trained on all aspects like file operations, office applications,



Khalid C, solutions architect
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taking back-ups and restoring databases on Ubuntu Linux. For this, our support team visited each society and trained the staff themselves," explains Khalid. Finding manpower for this support has also been a constant challenge. Khalid adds, "With NIC's support, the DCS formed a formal committee, but it has not been set up well

yet. Their salary comes from the cooperative societies' contributions, and we still find it difficult to get employees with expertise in PHP and Linux to stay here for a long tenure."

Some of the other challenges faced in the initial stages were architecture compatibility of open source tools, finding open source solutions for various requirements, and the selection of the right open source tools. For this, the software development team and NIC interacted regularly with the online open source communities to overcome the issues.

Just around the corner

The DCSs are still looking for people who can add to their support team. The committee members still feel that the challenges they have faced are minuscule compared to the benefits they have received. At present, 50 societies are still running on Lypsaa, and they gradually plan to migrate to OpenLypsaa over the next two years, until the DCSs completely run on open source. 

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